tion veterans and also hold on to his home ground against Modi, much like the southern leaders have done successfully. In the South, where Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Kerala together account for 101 seats, the BJP won just four seats in 2019, all of them from Telangana. The party will find it very difficult to make any gains in these states. And even if the BJP sweeps the Lok Sabha seats in MP, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh as it did in 2019 and holds on to its bastions like UP and Gujarat, they would add up to less than 200 seats. It, therefore, needs major gains in big states such as Maharashtra, Bihar, West Bengal, Odisha and Telangana to ensure it crosses the majority mark of 272 again on its own.

Thus while the saffron party remains in pole position for the 2024 general election, the BJP's quest for a third term will be no straight contest. The man himself, though, continues to straddle the Indian political landscape like a Colossus and so far has no real alternative in the Opposition to challenge his supremacy. This one factor alone may make the BJP's rocky road to victory far smoother.

## THE ECONOMY WORRY

**More than politics,** it could be the economics that could mar Modi's quest for a third term in 2024. Even before Covid-19 struck the country in early 2020, economic growth had hovered in the sub-5 per cent range for several quarters in a row, far below the country's potential. The pandemic and the consequent lockdowns dragged it down further, with fiscal 2020-21 registering two consecutive quarters of negative growth. India has recovered subsequently, but the worry is if this rebound is sustainable. Already, a host of agencies as well as the central bank have revised India's growth estimates for the current fiscal, betraying how vulnerable the economy continues to be as a cluster of external shocks coupled with high inflation and rising interest rates dampen domestic demand. In November, Moody's cut its India GDP growth forecast for 2022 to 7 per cent from its earlier estimates of 7.7 per cent, as did the RBI, which revised the country's growth rate estimates for 2022-23 to 7 per cent from 7.2 per cent earlier.

With things unlikely to get better in a hurry, it will be cause for worry for Modi and the BJP. Geopolitical uncertainty in the wake of the continuing war in Ukraine is a key factor. All indications are towards an escalation of the war this winter, feeding inflation across the globe as commodity prices, including of crude, could rise once again. Commodity prices had indeed climbed down from the high levels they had reached immediately after Russia's Ukraine invasion in February (crude, for instance, was trading at around $86 a barrel on December 4 compared to over $130 weeks after Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February), but the relief seems to be driven by prospects of an impending recession, which again is bad news for the global economy.

Countries like India, which heavily depend on crude imports—over 80 per cent of our crude oil requirement is imported—are already seeing their trade deficit balloon on account of the high cost of imports and lower revenues from exports. With Russia saying that more strikes on energy targets are 'inevitable', many experts are expecting crude prices to inch back to $100 a barrel in the coming months. Geopolitical uncertainty also affects private investment, which except for a few sectors within infrastructure, has been stagnant for some time now. For the second half of the year, GDP growth will slow down to 4.6 per cent, due to the base effect from last year and the slowing global growth, says D.K. Joshi, chief economist with Crisil.

This cannot be good news for the ruling party. Rising prices and unemployment have a major bearing on electoral fortunes, and remain matters of concern for the BJP. The past few months have seen inflation burn a hole in the common man's pockets. Although retail inflation, measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI), fell to a three-month low of 6.77 per cent for


